BERNSTEIN
SOCIETE GENERALE GROUP

5 November 2026


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Global Digital Assets

Circle Internet Group

Rating

Outperform

Price Target

CRCL **145.00 USD**

Circle Q3: Code is cheap, liquidity isn't. Now perhaps buy more payments distribution

A line that stuck with us from this a16z piece (**When software stops being the moat**) - 'You can't vibe code USDC'. Liquidity propagated by blockchain financial networks is hardest to build. CRCL maintained a market share of 27% this quarter and increased market share of volumes to 79% (vs. 66% in 3Q2025), demonstrating liquidity effects are more persistent. Q3 revenue beat estimates by 11% at $865Mn and EPS of $0.89 came in 2.4x consensus ($0.37). Adjusted EBITDA at $317Mn beat consensus by 56%. The beat is attributable to the recognition of $182Mn of ARC Token presale revenue following Arc's public mainnet launch on September 16. Stripping out Arc, the underlying picture is softer: other revenue ex-Arc was $25Mn (-26% QoQ), RLDC margin ex-Arc was 39.7% (-150bps QoQ), and adj. EBITDA margin ex-Arc was 50% (vs. 70% reported).

Stablecoin competition is pushing hard on distribution including sharing yield more liberally with the partners - OUSD (Stripe & consortium), RLUSD (Ripple) and USDG (Paxos with Robinhood as anchor partner) and several bank sponsored stablecoins/deposit tokens. We believe, to endure Circle's lead, we would like to see management step up on selective payments focused acquisitions integrating USDC within traditional payments plumbing. This could help build a more defensible fee income business (considering float income is harder to defend). The recent Tazapay (not covered) acquisition is a small step in the right direction, but we would like to see more.

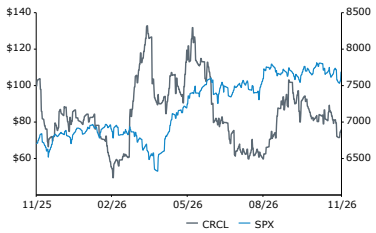
1. USDC in Circulation: USDC ended Q3 at $73.9Bn, flat YoY and up 1% QoQ, with average circulation of $73.3Bn (+8% YoY) but down 4% from Q2's high. Stablecoin market share stayed flat at 27% QoQ. On-platform USDC rose 36% YoY to $13.9Bn, or 19% of circulation (vs. 17% in 2Q2026; 14% in 3Q2025). Net reserve margin was 37.8%, up ~70bps YoY but down ~80bps QoQ, reflecting the first full quarter of the Hyperliquid arrangement (balances sit on Coinbase). Despite flat supply, usage continues to grow. USDC transaction volume stood at ~$14Tn in 3Q2026 (up 49% YoY), accounting for 79% of total stablecoin volumes (vs. 66% in 3Q2025). Primary market liquidity set a record at $208Bn minted and redeemed (+42% YoY), or ~$2.3Bn per day vs. $1.9Bn in Q2, with over $520Bn YTD - this liquidity infrastructure is the hardest part of the moat to replicate. ***Continued on page 2...***

Close Date	4 Nov 2026
CRCL Close Price (USD)	76.12
Price Target (USD)	145.00
Upside/(Downside)	90%
52-Week Range	140.00/49.90
SPX	7,688.62
FYE	Dec
Div Yield	NA
Market Cap (USD) (M)	19,529
EV (USD) (M)	17,830

Performance	YTD	1M	6M	12M
Absolute (%)	(4.0)	(6.3)	(36.3)	(31.6)
SPX (%)	12.3	(0.4)	6.8	13.5
Relative (%)	(16.3)	(5.9)	(43.1)	(45.1)

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

Price Performance, 1YR



Investment Implications

We rate CRCL Outperform (PT$145).

Reported EPS	F25A	F26E	F27E
CRCL (USD)	(0.44)	1.17	2.31

Financials	F25A	F26E	F27E	CAGR
EBITDA (M)	585.22	720.13	1,129	38.9%

Valuation Metrics	F25A	F26E	F27E
Reported P/E (x)	(173.8)	64.9	32.9

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

See the Disclosure Appendix of this report for required disclosures, analyst certifications and other important information. Alternatively, visit our Global Research Disclosure Website.

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DETAILS

2. Other revenue: Other revenue was $207Mn (~6x QoQ), of which $182Mn was ARC Token presale revenue recognized on the minting and delivery of ARC Tokens and the public mainnet launch (75% of the total $242Mn presale). Excluding Arc, other revenue was $25Mn, down 26% QoQ, due to lower blockchain integrations in the quarter. Associated other costs were $2.5Mn. Management expects other revenue ex-Arc to step up in Q4 with several blockchain integrations in the pipeline. FY2026 other revenue guidance of $310-330Mn is unchanged and comprises the $182Mn of Arc presale revenue plus $130-150Mn from the remainder of the product suite.

3. Financials: Total revenue stood at $865Mn (+17% YoY; +23% QoQ). Reserve income of $658Mn (-8% YoY, -2% QoQ) contributed ~76% of total revenue, with other revenue's share increasing from ~5% to ~24% sequentially on the Arc token recognition. Total distribution, transaction and other costs were $412Mn (-8% YoY, flat QoQ). RLDC (revenue less distribution costs) of $453Mn grew 55% YoY and 57% QoQ, with RLDC margin of 52.4% (vs. 41.2% in 2Q2026), driven by Arc token presale revenue, which carries no distribution cost. Excluding Arc, RLDC margin was 39.7%, down ~150bps QoQ due to lower net reserve margin and weaker other revenue. Net reserve margin was 37.8%, up ~70bps YoY but down ~80bps QoQ, reflecting the first full quarter of the Hyperliquid arrangement (balances sit on Coinbase).

Adj. operating expenses were $139Mn (+13% YoY, -5% QoQ), with the YoY increase driven by Arc and AI infrastructure investment and marketing, and the sequential decline reflecting non-recurring costs in Q2. Adj. EBITDA stood at $317Mn (+85% YoY, +121% QoQ) with margin of 70% - but 50% excluding Arc, in line with Q2.

4. Technology stack and applications:

(i) Layer-1 blockchain - Arc: Arc public mainnet went live September 16 with 11 founding institutional validators and 100+ applications on day one. Builders include BNY (not covered), HSBC (not covered), State Street (not covered), Mastercard (covered by Bernstein), Visa (covered by Bernstein), and DeFi protocols including Aave (not covered), Morpho (not covered) and Uniswap (not covered). Roadmap items include three purpose-built "Arc sectors" — privacy (opt-in confidentiality with selective disclosure), payments (targeting >100,000 TPS), and agents (verified identity, mandates, audit trails) - ahead of a proof-of-stake (PoS) transition in 2027.

Arc monetization framework: Management laid out three revenue paths, all recognized in other revenue. (1) Staking rewards - post-PoS, Circle expects to stake its holdings and operate as a validator, earning ARC tokens; this is expected to be the primary source of recurring Arc revenue and to build over time. (2) Token sales - selective sales to advance network development, with no associated costs, so proceeds flow directly to the bottom line. (3) Ecosystem incentives - tokens distributed to developers and partners, recognized at market value in other revenue with an offsetting entry in other distribution costs, and therefore RLDC-neutral.

(ii) CPN: Circle Payments Network annualized TPV reached $41.3Bn on a trailing 30-day basis at quarter end, up more than 15x YoY and ~3x since end-June. Enrolled financial institutions grew more than 4x YoY to 205 (from 175 in Q2). Momentum has accelerated further post-quarter: as of October 30, annualized volume surpassed $58Bn. CPN is now live on Arc mainnet, with Arc positioned as the preferred settlement layer. Treasury integrations with Kyriba and Tereina (both - not covered) open access to SAP ERP customers, and CPN Managed Payments has been extended to support AI agent payments. Management has begun monetizing CPN flows and expects material CPN revenue in 2027, particularly post-Tazapay (Singapore-headquartered B2B cross-border payments platform) integration.

(iii) Agentic payments: Over 99% of agent payments on the x402 protocol settle in USDC, and nearly 2,800 endpoints are now listed in Circle's agent marketplace (vs. 900+ paid services in Q2). Management targets Q1 2027 for a full stack where an agent built on Arc can be discovered, hired, paid and trusted on its track record.

5. New partnerships and corporate actions:

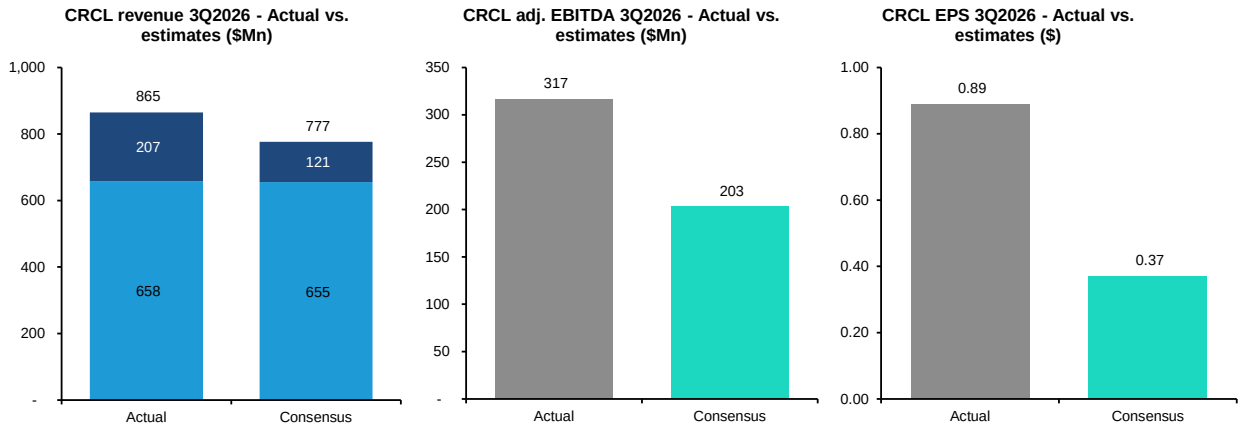
- **Tazapay (acquisition):** Circle signed a definitive agreement to acquire Tazapay (not covered), a Singapore-headquartered B2B cross-border payments platform, for $400Mn in Class A common stock, with closing expected in 2027 pending regulatory approvals. Tazapay brings $25Bn+ in annualized payment volume, 60+ banking and fintech partners, and local payout rails across 100+ markets, with ~60% of its transaction volume already involving stablecoins. It has been a CPN design partner since 2025. The strategic logic is last-mile delivery - landing payments in local currency in APAC, LATAM and emerging markets, where CPN currently depends on third-party rails.

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- **Binance (not covered):** A new 5-year agreement alongside a $100Mn equity investment in Circle. There are no upfront costs associated with the renewal, but Q4 will be the first full quarter of the incentive arrangement, which will weigh on net reserve margin.
- **Tereina (not covered):** The SAP-backed company is integrating USDC and EURC into enterprise payment workflows across the SAP ecosystem.
- **Visa:** Moved Visa Direct stablecoin prefunding from pilot to commercial deployment with Inyo Global, covering 180+ countries
- **Samsung (covered by Bernstein):** Samsung Wallet now enables eligible US Galaxy users to send USDC to bank accounts in 60+ countries.

6. FY2026 Guidance: Circle reaffirmed all four guided metrics. Other revenue remains $310-330Mn for FY2026 (including recognized ARC presale revenue), RLDC margin remains 41.7-43.7% (including Arc), adj. operating expenses remain $570-585Mn with management continuing to trend toward the high end, and USDC circulation guidance is unchanged at a multi-year through-cycle 40% CAGR. Management expects full-year RLDC margin, excluding Arc revenue, to be near the midpoint of the original 38-40% range, with a step down in the Q4 net reserve margin driven by the full-quarter impact of Hyperliquid and Binance incentive arrangements.

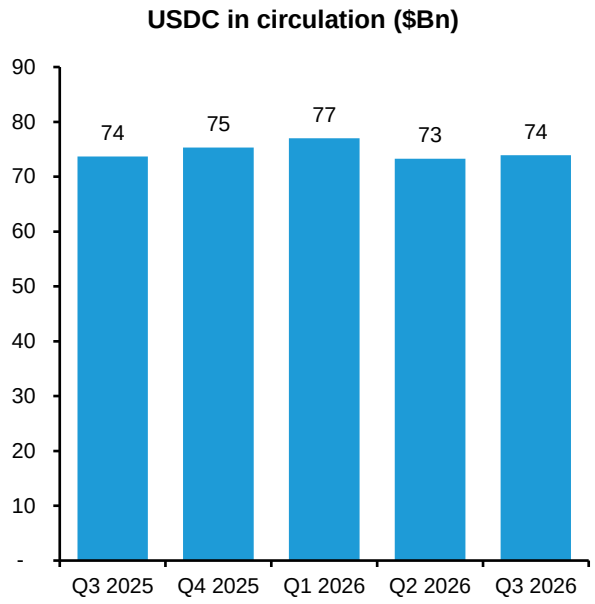
EXHIBIT 1: **CRCL 3Q26 - Actual vs. estimates**



Source: Company filings, Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

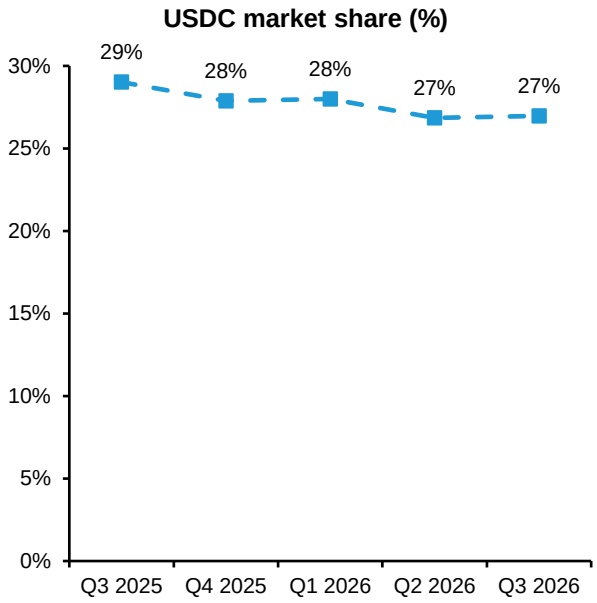
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EXHIBIT 2: **USDC supply, EOP**



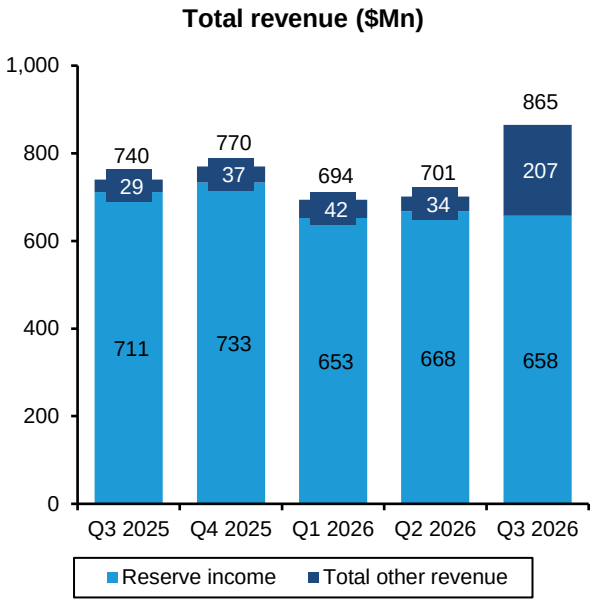
Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 3: **USDC market share among dollar-backed stablecoins**



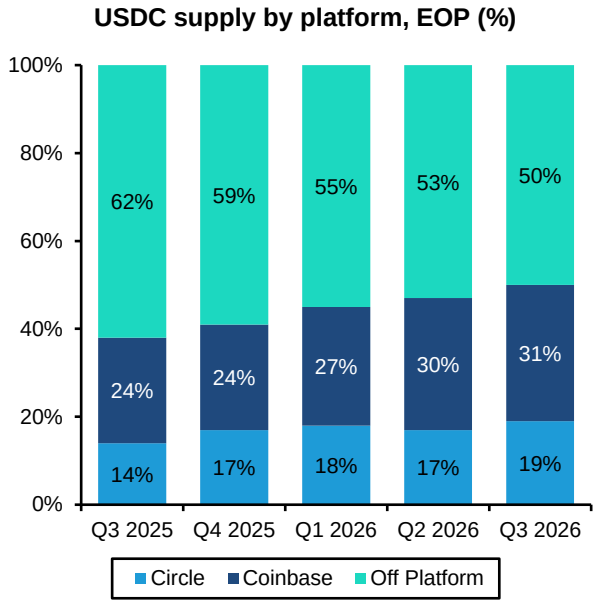
Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 4: **Circle's total revenue ($Mn)**



Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

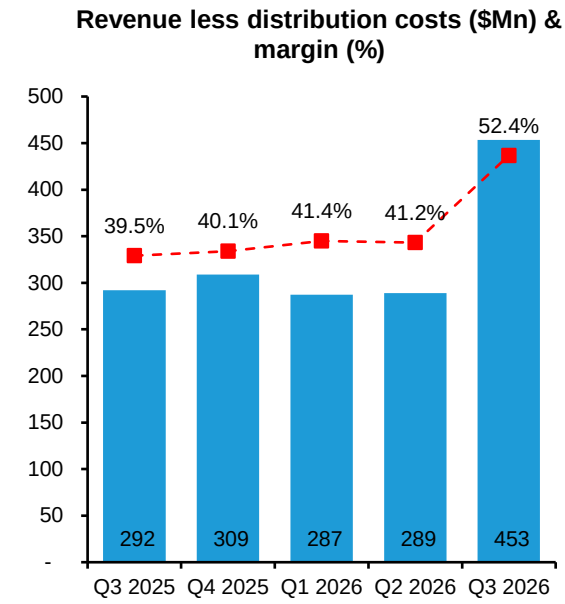
EXHIBIT 5: **USDC supply split across platforms**



Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

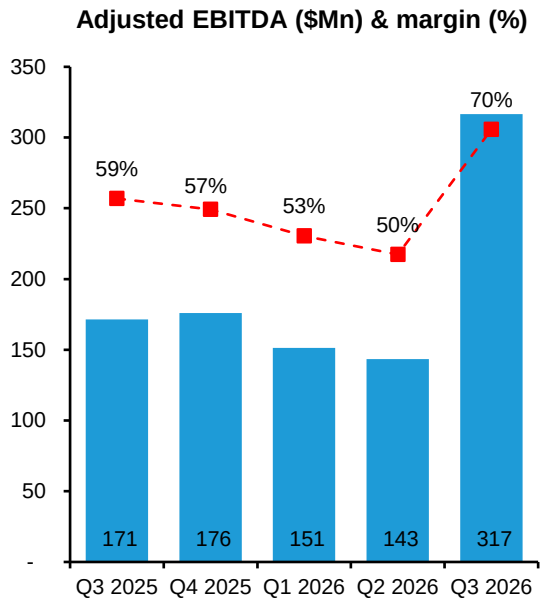
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EXHIBIT 6: **Circle's revenue less distribution costs ($Mn)**



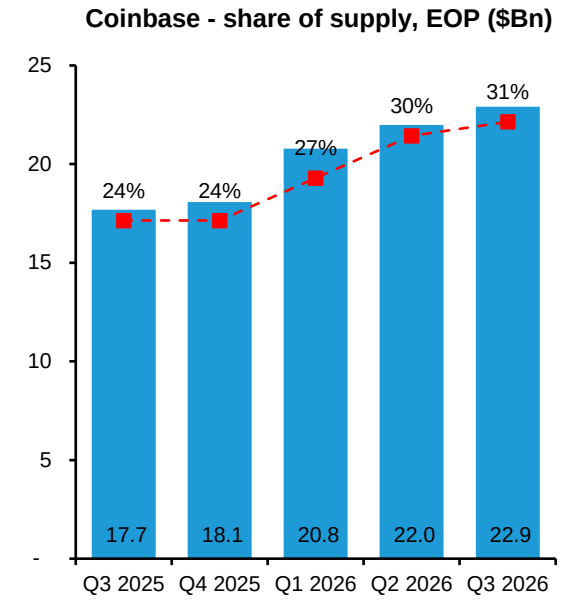
Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 7: **Circle's adjusted EBITDA**



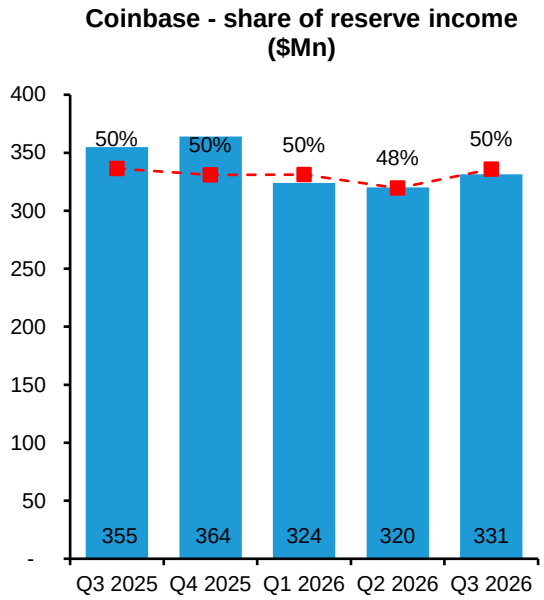
Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 8: **Coinbase's share of USDC supply, EOP**



Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 9: **Coinbase's stablecoin revenue ($Mn) and Coinbase's share of total reserve income (%)**



Source: Company filings, Bernstein analysis

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APPENDIX - FINANCIAL FORECASTS

EXHIBIT 10: **Circle - Income statement**

($mn, except mentioned)	2025A	2026E	2027E	2028E
USDC in circulation, EOP ($bn)	75	83	128	172
Income Statement				
Reserve income	2,637	2,732	4,033	5,284
Total other revenue	110	322	482	646
Total revenue	**2,747**	**3,054**	**4,515**	**5,930**
Total Distribution & Transaction Costs	1,664	1,750	2,635	3,467
Revenue less distribution costs	1,083	1,305	1,880	2,464
Revenue less distribution costs margin (%)	*39%*	*43%*	*42%*	*42%*
Compensation	845	554	596	659
General & Administrative	190	260	301	333
Depreciation & Amortization	77	116	120	120
IT Infrastructure	37	63	72	78
Marketing	26	35	53	78
Other	5	0	-	-
Operating Expenses	1,179	1,028	1,142	1,268
Other income (expense)	(6)	53	66	93
Income tax expense	(33)	39	217	348
Net income	(70)	291	587	941
EPS - basic ($)	**(0.44)**	**1.17**	**2.31**	**3.71**
Adjusted EBITDA	**585**	**720**	**1,129**	**1,628**
(% margin)	54%	55%	60%	66%

Source: Company filings, Bernstein estimates and analysis

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BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

			4 Nov 2026		TTM	Reported EPS				Reported P/E (x)	
			Closing	Price	Rel.						
Ticker	Rating	Cur	Price	Target	Perf.	Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
CRCL (Circle)	O	USD	76.12	145.00	(45.1)%	USD	(0.44)	1.17	2.31	(173.8)	64.9	32.9
SPX			7,688.62									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

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VALUATION METHODOLOGY

Circle Internet Group

We value CRCL on a long-term DCF approach, given the long term potential for exponential TAM expansion driven by stablecoin’s potential applications in payments & stablecoin-native financial services. We assume a WACC of 10.3%, and terminal growth rate of 2% to get a price target of $145. Based on the Enterprise Value (from DCF), we arrive at ~21x EV/ ‘28 adj. EBITDA.

RISKS

Circle Internet Group

1. Digital Assets are a new asset class with limited price history and often display high-beta volatility to changes in macro including any recessionary challenges in US Circle has near term dependence on crypto capital markets.

2. Risk of fresh competition from banks, payment players as regulatory clarity emerges in the US and globally.

3. Monoline revenue model - 99% driven by interest income, thus being sensitive to step decline in rates.

RATINGS DEFINITIONS, BENCHMARKS AND DISTRIBUTION

EQUITY RATINGS DEFINITIONS

Bernstein brand

The Bernstein brand rates stocks based on forecasts of relative performance for the next 12 months versus the S&P 500 for stocks listed on the U.S. and Canadian exchanges, versus the Bloomberg Europe Developed Markets Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index EUR (EDME) for stocks listed on the European exchanges and emerging markets exchanges outside of the Asia Pacific region, versus the Bloomberg Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index USD (JPL) for stocks listed on the Japanese exchanges, and versus the Bloomberg Asia ex-Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index (ASIAX) for stocks listed on the Asian (ex-Japan) exchanges -unless otherwise specified.

The Bernstein brand has three categories of ratings:

- Outperform: Stock will outpace the market index by more than 15 pp
- Market-Perform: Stock will perform in line with the market index to within +/-15 pp
- Underperform: Stock will trail the performance of the market index by more than 15 pp

Coverage Suspended: Coverage of a company under the Bernstein research brand has been suspended. Ratings and price targets are suspended temporarily, are no longer current, and should therefore not be relied upon.

Not Rated: A rating assigned when the stock cannot be accurately valued, or the performance of the company accurately predicted, at the present time. The covering analyst may continue to publish research reports on the company to update investors

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on events and developments.

Not Covered (NC) denotes companies that are not under coverage.

Bernstein brand stock ratings are based on a 12-month time horizon.

Autonomous brand – common stocks

The Autonomous brand rates common stocks as indicated below. As our benchmarks we use the Bloomberg Europe 600 Financials Price Return Index (E600BK) and Bloomberg Europe Dev Mkt Financials Large and Mid Cap Price Ret Index EUR (EDMFI) index for developed European banks and Payments, the Bloomberg Europe 600 Insurance Price Return Index (E600IN) for European insurers, the S&P 500 and S&P Financials for US banks and Payments coverage, S5LIFE for US Insurance, the S&P Insurance Select Industry (SPSIINS) for US Non-Life Insurers coverage, the Bloomberg Emerging Markets Financials Large, Mid and Small Cap Price Return Index (EMLSF) for emerging market banks and insurers and Payments, and the Bloomberg Japan Financials Large & Mid Cap Price Return Index (JPFILM) for Japanese Financials. Ratings are stated relative to the sector (not the market).

The Autonomous brand has three categories of common stock ratings:

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- Underperform (UP): Stock will trail the performance of the relevant index by more than 10 pp

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Those denoted as 'Feature' (e.g., Feature Outperform FOP, Feature Under Outperform FUP) are our core ideas.

Not Covered (NC) denotes companies that are not under coverage.

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- Neutral (N): The total return of the preferred instrument is expected to perform in line with preferred securities of other issuers operating in similar sectors or rating categories over the next six months.
- Underperform (UP): The total return of the preferred instrument is expected to underperform preferred securities of other issuers operating in similar sectors or rating categories over the next six months.

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Where this report contains investment recommendations for credit instruments, as defined in article 3(1)(35) of the Market Abuse Regulation, the information below is presented to comply with its disclosure requirements.

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- Credit Underperform (C-UP): The total return of the Reference Credit Instrument is expected to underperform the credit spread of bonds of other issuers operating in similar sectors or rating categories over the next six months.

Autonomous credit ratings are based on a 6-month time horizon.

A list of all investment recommendations produced by the author(s) of this report alongside credit ratings history are available upon request.

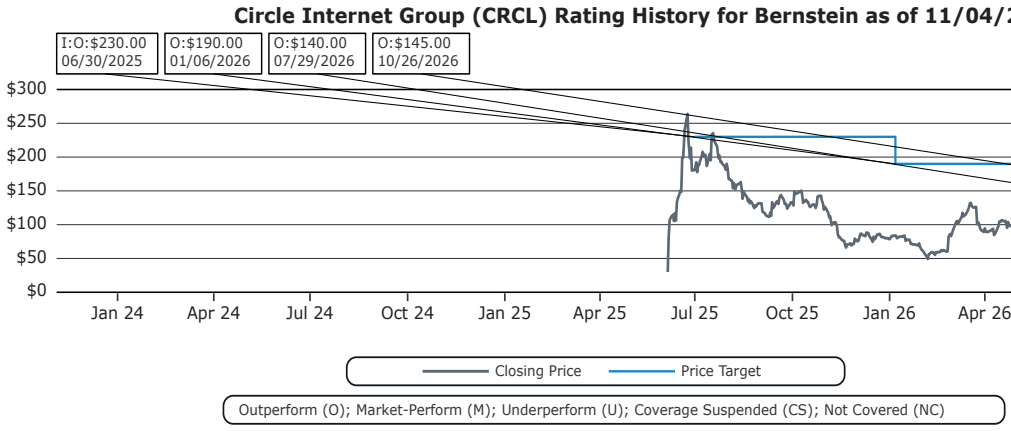
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DISTRIBUTION OF EQUITY RATINGS/INVESTMENT BANKING SERVICES

Equity Rating	Market Abuse Regulation (MAR) and FINRA Rating Category	Global Rating Distribution	Investment Banking Relationships*
Outperform	BUY	52.3%	14.2%
Market-Perform (Bernstein Brand) Neutral (Autonomous Brand)	HOLD	35.6%	16.1%
Underperform	SELL	12.1%	13.6%

* These figures represent the percentage of companies within each equity rating category for which affiliates of Bernstein have provided investment banking services within the previous 12 months.
As of September 30, 2026. All figures are updated quarterly.

PRICE CHARTS / RATINGS AND PRICE TARGET HISTORY



Circle Internet Group is covered by both the Autonomous and Bernstein brands. For the research ratings and price target history please go to https://bernstein-autonomous.bluematrix.com/sellside/Disclosures.action.

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All price target and closing price data in the chart(s) above are denominated in the currency noted in the Ticker Table of this report.

CONFLICTS OF INTEREST

Gautam Chhugani maintains long positions in various crypto currencies.

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